

# Josephine Auer

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## Research Fields

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Primary: Microeconomic Theory, Behavioural Economics

Secondary: Organisational Economics, Econometrics

## Education

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### Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT)

Cambridge, MA

PhD in Economics, expected 2031

Current cumulative graduate GPA: 5.0/5.0

Kenan Sahin Presidential Fellow

### University of Oxford

Oxford, UK

MPhil in Economics, 2023–2025

Distinction

Rhodes Scholar (Queensland and Magdalen College), University of Oxford

### The University of Queensland

Brisbane, Australia

Bachelor of Mathematics, 2022 (GPA: 7.0/7.0)

Bachelor of Advanced Finance and Economics (Honours Class I), 2019 (GPA: 7.0/7.0)

Vice Chancellor's Scholar

## Graduate Coursework

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### MIT Fall 2025 (completed):

14.164 Foundations of Behavioural Economics (A), 14.281 Contract Economics (A), ECON2059 Decision Theory (A), 14.271 Industrial Organisation I (listener)

### MIT Spring 2026 (in progress):

14.163 Algorithms and Behavioural Science, 14.283 Advanced Topics in Organisational Economics I, 14.284 Advanced Topics in Organisational Economics II, 14.126 Game Theory (listener), 14.273 Advanced Topics in Industrial Organisation (listener)

## Research Papers

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### Under review

*A Secret Worth Keeping? Bid Cap Design in Budget-Constrained Procurement Auctions* (with Lana Friesen and Ian A. MacKenzie)

### Under review

*Hedonic Habits: The Empirical Content of Dynamic Hedonic Models*

## Research in Progress

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- *The Impacts of AI on Help Seeking*: how private AI can substitute for socially costly human asking and alter advice-following and verification behaviour.
- *Does AI Kill Deals?*: whether role-specific AI advice to different parties can destroy bargaining viability even when each recommendation is locally coherent.
- *Supernormal Food Demand*: a structural framework for food demand in which vivid benefits and shrouded costs can generate excess demand and a wedge between observed choice and welfare.
- *Behavioural Consensus Building*: how public deliberation and social pressure can create norm cascades that suppress scrutiny rather than improve information aggregation.
- *Modern Slavery*: a decision-theoretic analysis of risky migration and trafficking vulnerability under uncertainty (with Ian Jewitt).
- *The Effects of Algorithmic Exposure in Media Markets*: dynamic demand, limited attention, recommendations, and habit formation in media markets.
- *Pandora's Box with Competition*: strategic search, inefficient stopping, and equilibrium distortions in competitive exploration (with Augustus Smith).

## Selected Policy Research Outputs

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- Auer, J. (2022), *Disengaged: The costs and possible causes of youth disengagement in Australia*, e61 Research Note Series.
- Andrews, D., Auer, J., Elias, M., La Cava, G., and Mercier, L. (2022), *The effect of the COVID-19 recession on the youth labour market in Australia*, e61 Institute.
- Adams, N., Andrews, D., Auer, J., Clarke, E., Hayward, Z., La Cava, G., and Nolan, M. (2022), *Preventing scarring in the post-pandemic youth labour market*, e61 Institute.
- Adams, N., Andrews, D., Auer, J., Dwyer, E., Hayward, Z., Kaplan, G., La Cava, G., Michielsen, A., and Nolan, M. (2022), *Better harnessing Australia's talent: five facts for the Summit*, e61 Institute.

## Research Experience

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|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------|
| <b>University of Oxford, Economics of Modern Slavery Initiative</b><br>Research Contributor | 2024–present |
| <b>e61 Institute</b><br>Predoctoral Analyst                                                 | 2022–2023    |
| <b>The University of Queensland, School of Economics</b><br>Economics Research Assistant    | 2019–2022    |

## Selected Honours and Awards

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Kenan Sahin Presidential Fellowship, MIT, 2025–present  
Rhodes Scholarship (Queensland), Oxford, 2023

University Medal, UQ, 2020

UQ Graduate of the Year, UQ, 2020

Valedictorian, UQ School of Economics, 2019

Vice Chancellor's Scholarship, UQ, 2016–2022